

LET ME TRY · FREE PRINTABLE

Calm-Down Toolkit

Big-feelings cards to print and cut · Ages 2–4

Practise these when your child is calm, like a game. Then, in a big moment, offer two choices: “Do you want to blow the candle or squeeze the pillow?”

Why it works

- Naming a feeling ('name it to tame it') helps a child's thinking brain calm the emotional brain (Siegel & Bryson, 2011).
- Children whose parents accept and talk about emotions ('emotion coaching') manage their feelings better over time (Gottman, 1997).

Breathing games

- Smell the flower, blow the candle
- Blow bubbles (real or pretend)
- Balloon belly: hands on tummy, fill it up slowly
- Snake breath: breathe in, hiss out slowly

Move it out

- Stamp your feet 10 times
- Squeeze a pillow as hard as you can
- Push the wall
- Jump like a frog

Words to say

- ○ “You're really angry. I'm here.”
- ○ “It's okay to be sad. I'll stay with you.”
- ○ “I won't let you hit. You can hit this pillow.”
- ○ “When you're ready, I'm ready for a hug.”

Calm corner kit

- ○ Two cushions and a soft blanket
- ○ A favourite soft toy
- ○ 2–3 books about feelings
- ○ A small sand timer or glitter jar to watch

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

Siegel, D. J., & Bryson, T. P. (2011). The Whole-Brain Child. Delacorte Press.
Gottman, J. (1997). Raising an Emotionally Intelligent Child. Simon & Schuster.

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